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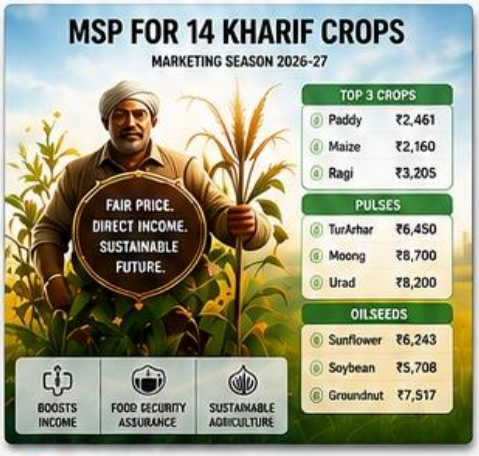


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India assumes Vice-Presidency of FATF for the first time; appoints Vivek Agrawal

In June 2025, India was elected as Vice-President of the Financial Task Force (FATF) for the first time. This reflects India's commitment to global standards in combating money laundering and terrorist financing.

Exam Hint:

- **What:** Vice-Presidency of FATF for the first time
- **Who:** Vivek Agrawal
- **Body:** Financial Action Task Force (FATF)
- **Term:** July 2025 to June 2027
- **Significance:** Helps build trust and recognition.

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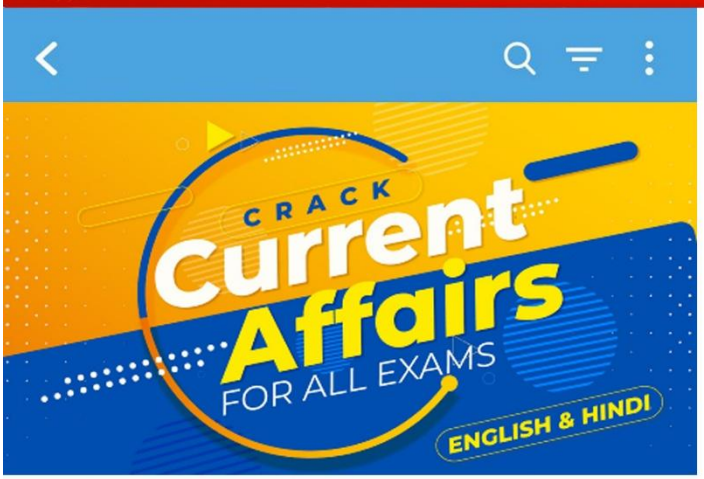
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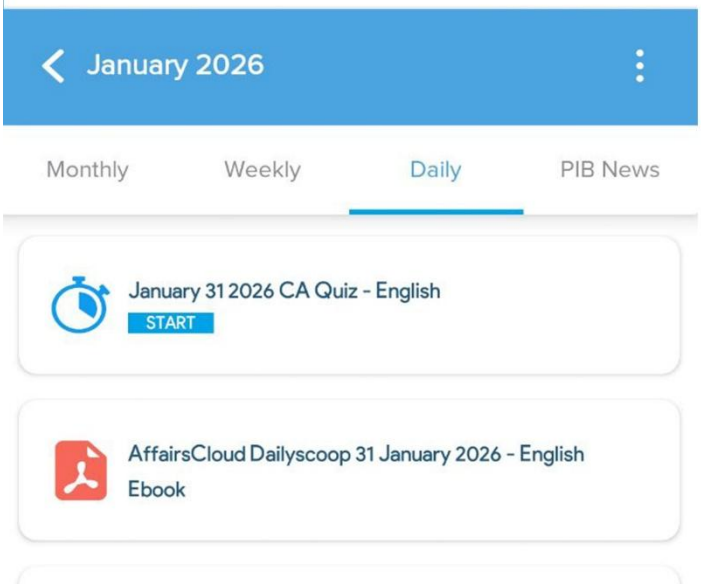
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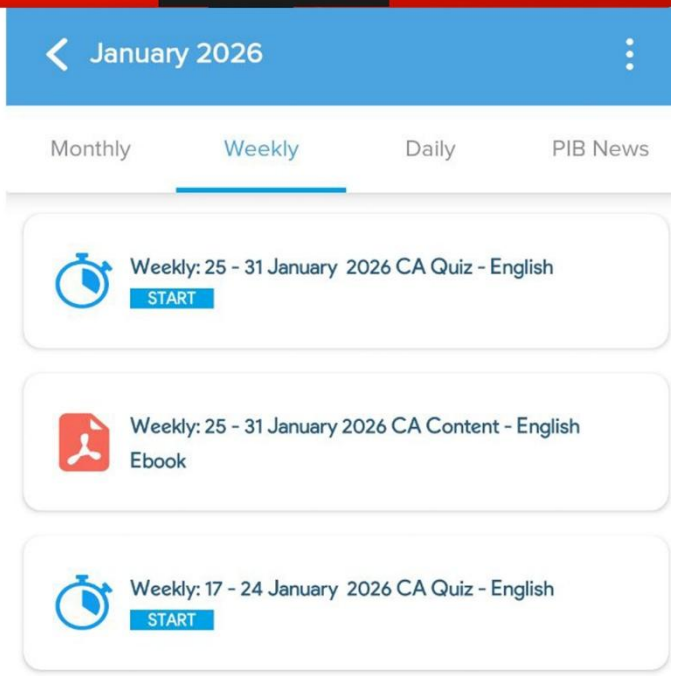
Bank & Insurance

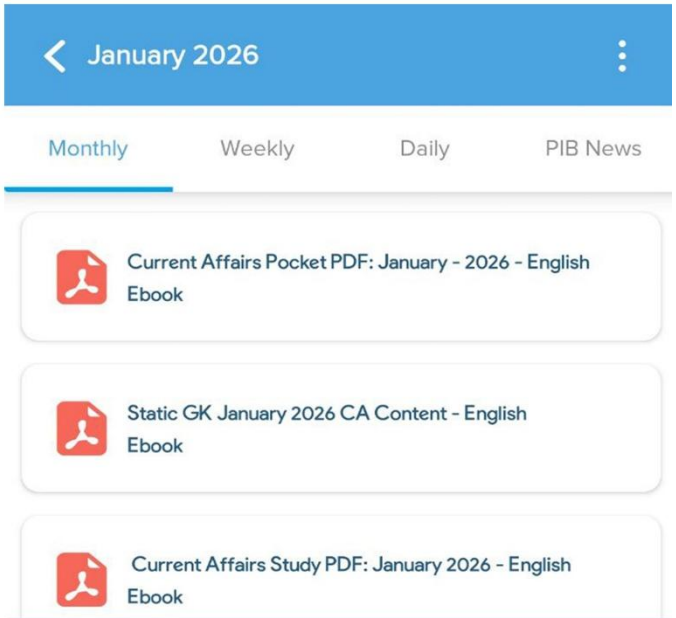
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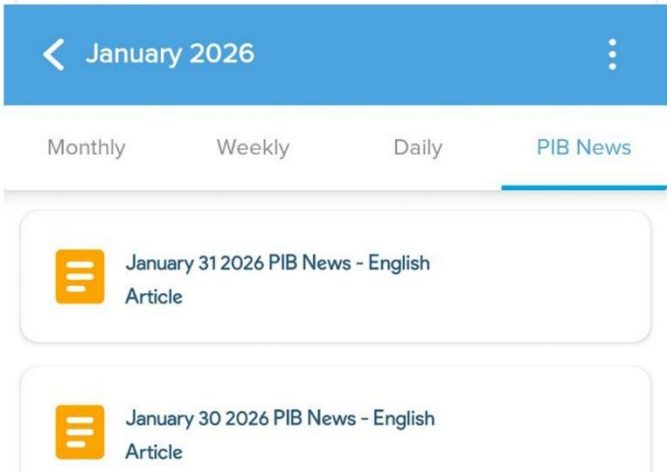
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HandWritten Notes

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NATIONAL AFFAIRS

1)

CBIC, DoR, MoF —Notified→ Key GST Changes under Finance Act, Section 1(2)(b) —Effective from→ November 01, 2026

🏛️ **Post-Sale Discounts:** Excluded from supply value through credit notes and ITC reversal; prior agreement not required.

📄 **Credit Notes:** Amended Section 15(3)(b) aligns with Section 34(1) of CGST Act, 2017, recognising post-supply discounts as valid grounds for GST credit notes.

💰 **Provisional Refunds:** 90% refund within 7 days for eligible inverted duty structure claims.

📦 **Export Refunds:** Rs. 1,000 minimum refund limit removed for exported goods.

CBIC – Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs

DoR – Department of Revenue

MoF – Ministry of Finance

GST – Goods and Services Tax

ITC – Input Tax Credit

CGST – Central Goods and Services Tax

2)

GoI —Constituted→ High-level Committee on Banking —for→ Viksit Bharat

↳ 👤 Chairperson: Suresh N. Patel, former CVC; tenure of 6 months.

🎯 **Objective:** Recommend banking reforms for a globally competitive, inclusive and resilient banking sector by 2047.

⚖️ **Regulatory Reforms:** Review banking laws and regulations, including RRBs and cooperative banks.

🌐 **Global Practices:** Assess prudential norms and international best practices to develop globally competitive banks.

💰 **Capital Requirements:** Review long-term capital needs of banks, DFIs and NBFCs.

📊 **Cost of Capital:** Examine financing cost differences and promote private investment.

🤖 **Technology:** Develop an AI and digital banking roadmap with cybersecurity safeguards.

👥 **Talent Development:** Recommend talent acquisition, skill development, capacity-building measures.

🤝 **Financial Inclusion:** Review PSL and LBS for effective and balanced credit delivery.

📌 **Additional Mandate:** Examine other banking matters referred by GoI.

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GoI – Government of India
CVC – Central Vigilance Commissioner
RRBs – Regional Rural Banks
DFIs – Development Financial Institutions
NBFCs – Non-Banking Financial Companies
AI – Artificial Intelligence
PSL – Priority Sector Lending
LBS – Lead Bank Scheme

3)

PM Narendra Modi —Inaugurated→ 2nd ESTIC —At→ Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, Delhi

(India's flagship annual STI event)

Event Overview

- Theme: "Creative Minds, Catalyzing Science, Empowering Technologies"
- Organised By: CSIR, MoS&T in partnership with CSIR-NIIST

New networking initiative

Global Connect Networking Event: Promote international research partnerships, industry-academia collaboration and commercialisation of innovations.

PM – Prime Minister
ESTIC – Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave
STI – Science, Technology and Innovation
CSIR – Council of Scientific and Industrial Research
MoS&T – Ministry of Science and Technology
NIIST – National Institute for Interdisciplinary Science and Technology

4)

Union MoS Sanjay Seth (MoD) —Inaugurated→ VISV-2026 —At→ Manekshaw Centre, New Delhi

Event Highlight:
Theme: "Showcasing Defence Capabilities, Strengthening Global Partnerships"
Organised By: DRDO with CENJOWS

Publication: Foreign-language compendium of DRDO products in Arabic, Spanish & French

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MoS – Minister of State

MoD – Ministry of Defence

VISV – Vision, Innovation, Synergy, Values

DRDO – Defence Research and Development Organisation

CENJOWS – Centre for Joint Warfare Studies

5)

Department of Posts Releases Commemorative Postage Stamps for Breast Cancer Awareness

Department of Posts (DoP) Ministry of Communications → Released → Commemorative Postage Stamps (Value of Rs.25 and Rs.50) → On → Breast Cancer Awareness

- **Design:** Highlights early detection and screening.
- **Collaboration:** DoP with MoHFW under NP-NCD.
- **Awareness:** Promotes timely treatment.
- **Availability:** Through Philately Bureaus and e-Post Office portal.

Abbreviations

MoHFW – Ministry of Health and Family Welfare

NP-NCD – National Programme for Prevention and Control of Non-Communicable Diseases.

6)

MoLE → Notifed → Two National Social Security Board → For → Unorganised and gig/platform workers

- **Tenure:** 3 years, chaired by Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya (MoLE), with Secretary (MoLE) Dr. Chandra Bhushan Kumar as Vice-Chairperson
- **Composition:** Government, trade unions, employers and worker representatives.
- **Aggregators:** Eternal, Swiggy, Zepto, Urban Company and Rapido.
- **Functions:** Recommend welfare schemes and monitor social security programmes.
- **Framework:** Code on Social Security, 2020, effective 21 November 2025.

MoLE – Ministry of Labour and Employment

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7)

IN-SPACe Selects Six Private Space Companies for AI INSPIRED Grants of Up to Rs. 1 Crore Each

IN-SPACe DoS **Selected** 6 private space companies **Under** AI INSPIRED programme

Funding:
Grants of up to Rs. 1 crore each, with a total outlay of Rs. 6 crore.

Start-ups:
- **Agnikul Cosmos** – Precision landing.
- **Digantara** – Space object evaluation.
- **EON Space Labs** – Space debris detection.
- **OrbitAid Aerospace** – Satellite servicing and refuelling.
- **Omnipresent Robot Technologies** – Target recognition and docking.
- **TakeMeToSpace** – Spacecraft autonomy and control.

Focus:
AI-based precision landing, space surveillance, debris detection and spacecraft autonomy.

Abbreviations

IN-SPACe	–	Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre
AI	–	Artificial Intelligence
DoS	–	Department of Space
INSPIRED	–	INnovating Space Performance with Intelligent Resilient Engines Development

INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS

1)

World Bank (WB) **Released** Report **Titled** India Poverty and Equity Brief: October 2026

- Poverty: Extreme poverty fell from 27.1% (2011) to 2.6% (2023).
- Progress: 496 million people moved above the USD 4.20 poverty line.
- Drivers: Consumption growth, employment and food subsidies.
- LMI Poverty: Declined from 57.7% to 16.1%.
- Projection: Expected to fall to 12.1% by 2028.
- MPI: Declined from 53.8% to 16.4% (2005–21).
- Gini Index: 23.0 in 2023.
- Gap: Rural poverty 19.3%; urban 8.6%.
- Region: Uttar Pradesh–West Bengal belt accounts for 57% of India's poor.
- Wages: Top 10% earners received around 13 times the earnings of the bottom 10%.
- Unemployment: Youth unemployment rose to 15.9% in Q1 FY27.

MPI – Multidimensional Poverty Index

FY – Financial Year

Q1 – First Quarter

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BANKING & FINANCE

1)

Asian Development Bank (ADB) —Approved→ USD 139.55 Million Loan —For→ Puducherry Integrated Urban Livability Improvement Project (PIULIP).

- Water: Upgrade 100 km and lay 80 km pipelines; reservoirs, metered areas and RO plants.
- Infrastructure: 4.5 km accessible walkways and improved drainage.
- Outcome: Improved water security, sanitation and climate resilience for 3.2 lakh+ people.
- Sewerage: 270 km new networks, 80 km rehabilitation and 50 MLD treatment plant.
- Governance: Better revenue collection, financial systems and digital services.

RO – Reverse Osmosis

MLD – Million Litres per Day

2)

Upstox Securities private Limited —Received→ SEBI Approval —To Operate as→ Online Board Platform Provider (OBPP)

- Framework: SEBI introduced the registration framework in 2023; nearly 40 firms approved.
- Access: Direct bond offerings, replacing India Bonds partnership.
- Investment & Returns: Minimum Rs. 1,000; indicative returns of 8%–16%.
- Ratings: Initial bonds expected to range from AAA to BBB–, subject to availability.

SEBI – Securities and Exchange Board of India

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AWARDS & RECOGNITIONS

1)

PB Engineer Wins ABU Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026

Nongmaithem Nandakumar Singh (Engineer in PB) **Wins** ABU Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026 **At** 63rd ABU General Assembly 2026 **In** Colombo, Sri Lanka

- **Presented by:** ABU
- **Received by:** Mihir Kumar Jha, Under Secretary, MIB
- **Recognition:** Broadcast technology and innovation

Key Innovations

- **DDPlayout:** Indigenous automated broadcasting software
- **Adopted by:** Multiple Doordarshan Kendras (DDKs)
- **DDSlowMo:** Cost-effective slow-motion replay system
- **Application:** National-level sporting events

Abbreviations

PB	–	Prasar Bharati
ABU	–	Asia-Pacific Broadcasting Union
MIB	–	Ministry of Information and Broadcasting

APPOINTMENTS & RESIGNATIONS

1)

IREDA Appoints Jatin Kumar Nayak as Chairman and Managing Director

ACC **Approved** Jatin Kumar Nayak **As** CMD of IREDA **Until** 30 September 2029 or further orders

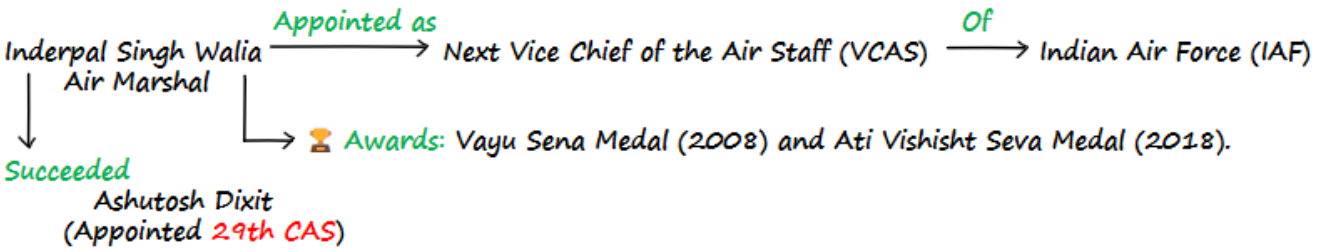
- **Predecessor:** Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty (Additional Charge)

Abbreviations

ACC	–	Appointments Committee of the Cabinet
CMD	–	Chairman & Managing Director
IREDA	–	Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Limited

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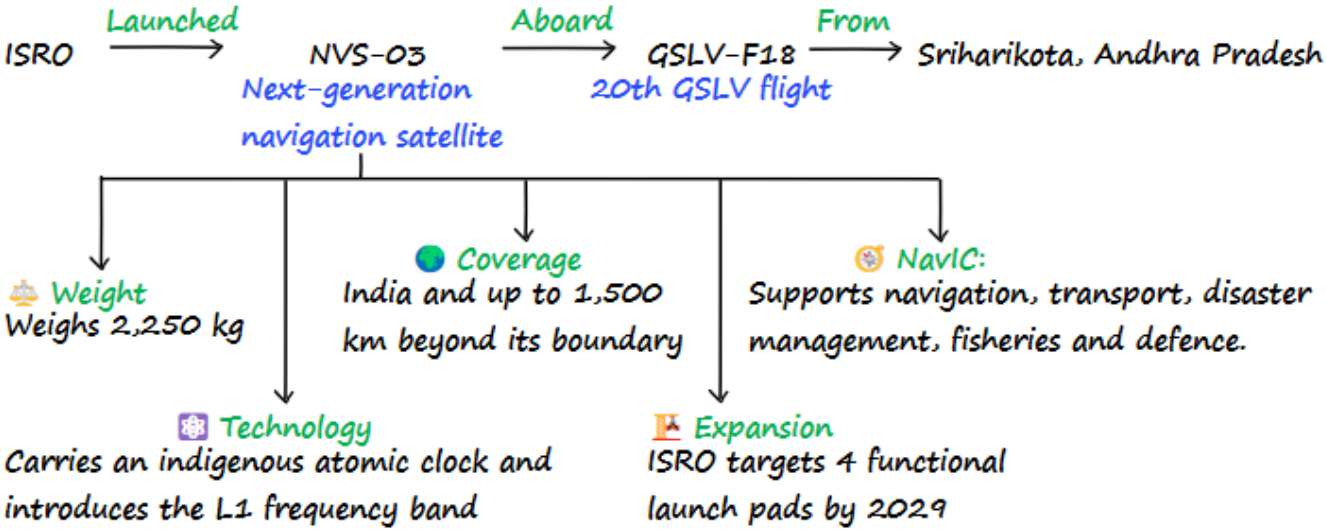
2)



CAS – Chief of the Air Staff

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

1)



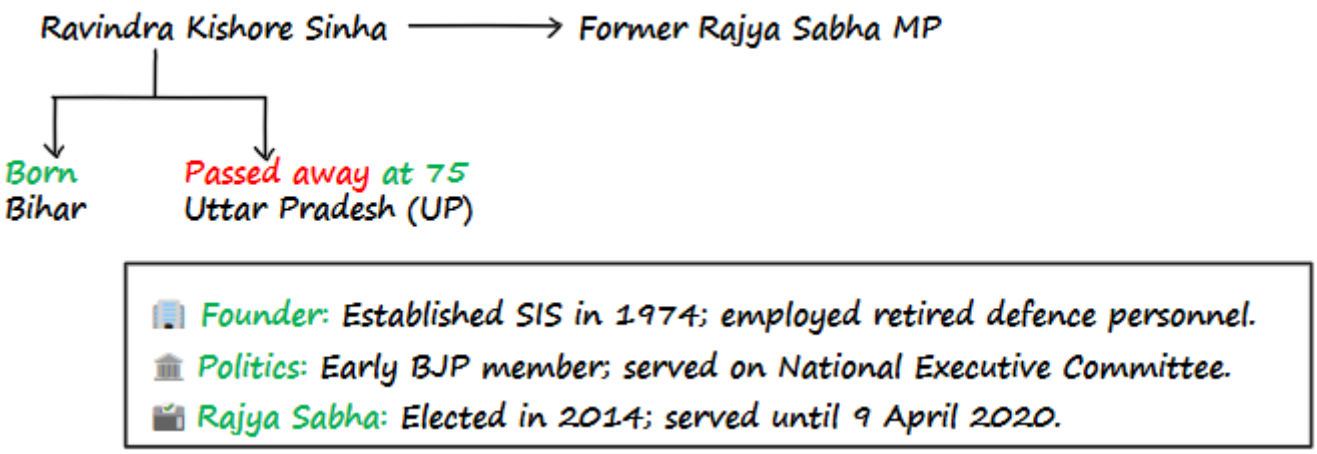
ISRO – Indian Space Research Organisation

GSLV – Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle

NavIC – Navigation with Indian Constellation

OBITUARY

1)



BJP – Bharatiya Janata Party

MP – Member of Parliament

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SIS – Security and Intelligence Services

IMPORTANT DAYS

1)

31 October 2026 ⟶ National Unity Day (Rashtriya Ekta Diwas)

Marks ↓ 151st birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel

2026 Events:

🎉 Celebrations: PM Modi led celebrations and paid tributes at Ekta Nagar.

🏗️ Projects: Projects worth Rs. 400+ crore launched at Ekta Nagar.

🎭 Bharat Parv: Celebrated under "Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat" until 15 November 2026.

🏅 Unity Award: Instituted in 2019; up to 3 recipients annually, with no cash prize.

- India's first Deputy Prime Minister
- First Home Minister in 1947
- Known as the Iron Man of India
- World's tallest statue "Statue of Unity" stands 182 metres tall inaugurated in Ekta Nagar, Gujarat in 2018
- Passed away on 15 December 1950

👮 Dakshata Padak: Instituted in 2024; 490 personnel honoured in 2026.

PM – Prime Minister

2)

1 November 2026 ⟶ World Vegan day ⟶ Promotes Animal welfare, cruelty-free living and environmental sustainability.

📜 Established: 1994 by Louise Wallis (50th anniversary of The Vegan Society).

🏛️ Vegan Society: Founded in November 1944 in the UK by Donald Watson and five others.

🗓️ First Observance: 1 November 1994. cut short

🎉 2026 Significance: 82nd anniversary of The Vegan Society and 32nd WVD.

WVD – World Vegan Day

UK – United Kingdom

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Detailed Content

Current Affairs 1 & 2 November 2026: Headlines



- CBIC Notifies Key GST Changes under Finance Act, 2026 Effective from November 01, 2026
- GoI Constitutes High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat, Chaired by Suresh N. Patel
- PM Narendra Modi inaugurates ESTIC 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi
- Union MoS Sanjay Seth Inaugurates विश्व-2026 (VISV-2026) at Maneskshaw Centre in New Delhi
- Department of Posts Releases Commemorative Postage Stamps on Breast Cancer Awareness
- MoLE Constitutes National Social Security Board for Unorganised, Gig and Platform Workers
- IN-SPACe Selects Six Private Space Companies for AI INSPIRED Grants of Up to Rs 1 Crore Each
- World Bank Report: India Records One of the World's Fastest Poverty Declines in 12 Years, to 2.6%
- ADB Approves USD 139.55 Million Loan for Urban Development in Puducherry
- Upstox Receives SEBI Approval to Operate as Online Bond Platform Provider
- PB Engineer Wins ABU Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026
- IREDA Appoints Jatin Kumar Nayak as Chairman and Managing Director
- Air Marshal Inderpal Singh Walia Appointed as Next Vice Chief of the IAF
- ISRO Successfully Launches NVS-03 Satellite Aboard GSLV-F18 from Sriharikota, AP
- Former Rajya Sabha MP Ravindra Kishore Sinha Passed Away at 75
- National Unity Day 2026 – October 31
- World Vegan Day 2026 – November 1

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NATIONAL AFFAIRS

CBIC Notifies Key GST Changes under Finance Act, 2026 Effective from November 01, 2026

In October 2026, the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs **(CBIC),** a statutory body under the Department of Revenue (DoR), Ministry of Finance (MoF), issued a notification in exercise of powers given under **Section 1(2)(b)** of the **Finance Act, 2026,** and appointed **November 01, 2026** as the date on which the key Goods and Services Tax (GST) changes introduced under the Act will come into force.

- The key GST changes are related to the treatment of post-sale discounts; provisional refunds under the inverted duty structure, aimed at easing compliance and enhancing liquidity flow for businesses.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Notification of Effective Date for Key GST Amendments
- ✓ **Notified by:** CBIC, MoF
- ✓ **Effective from:** November 01, 2026
- ✓ **GST Amendments Through:** Finance Act, 2026
- ✓ **Key Changes:** Post-Supply Discounts, Credit Notes, Provisional Refunds and Export Refund Threshold
- ✓ **Provisional Refund:** Up to 90% of Eligible Refund Amount
- ✓ **Export Refund Relaxation:** Removal of Rs 1,000 Minimum Threshold



Key GST Changes:

Post-Supply Discounts: The amended section 15 (3)(b) of the Act introduced the provision to exclude post-supply discounts from the value of supply if the supplier issues a credit note and the recipient reverses the corresponding Input Tax Credit (ITC), without the requirement of prior agreement or strict invoice-wise linkage.

Credit Notes: Section aligned with the statutory provisions under Section 34(1) of the Central Goods, Services and Tax (CGST Act, 2017) to explicitly cover post-supply discounts as a valid ground for issuing GST credit notes.

Provisional Refunds for Inverted Duty Structure: Section 54(6) of the Act extends the statutory provisional refund mechanism to eligible inverted duty structure claims, enabling businesses to receive 90% of eligible refunds provisionally within 7 days, subject to conditions.

Removal of Export Refund Limit: In addition, the amended section 54(14) removes the Rs 1,000 minimum refund restriction for tax paid on goods exported out of India, benefiting small exporters.

- However, this relaxation is not applicable to other refund categories.

Background:

Union Budget 2026–27: The GST amendments were proposed in the Union Budget for Financial Year 2026–27 (FY27), presented by Union Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Ministry of Finance, on 1 February 2026.

About Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC):

Chairman- Vivek Chaturvedi
Headquarters- New Delhi, Delhi
Established in- 1964

GoI Constitutes High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat, Chaired by Suresh N. Patel

In October 2026, the Ministry of Finance **(MoF)**, Government of India (GoI), announced the constitution of a

High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat, chaired by **Suresh N. Patel**, former Central Vigilance Commissioner **(CVC)**, with a tenure of **six months**.

- The newly formed committee has been tasked to undertake a comprehensive review of the country's banking sector and recommend structural, institutional, regulatory and legislative reforms to make it globally competitive, financially inclusive and resilient for Viksit Bharat, 2047.

Exam Hints:

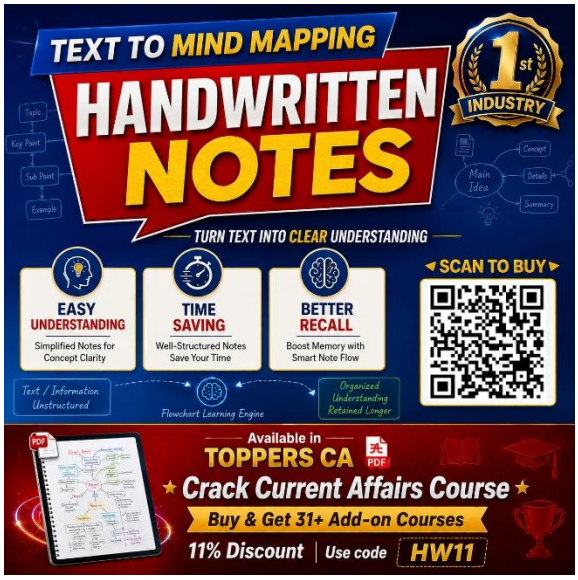
- ✓ **What?** Constitution of High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat
- ✓ **Announced by:** MoF
- ✓ **Chaired by:** Suresh N. Patel, formed CVC
- ✓ **Tenure:** Six months
- ✓ **Members:** Shirish Chandra Murmu, Padmaja Chunduru and N. S. Vishwanathan
- ✓ **Member Secretary:** Joint Secretary (Banking), DFS, MoF

Key Details of the Committee:

Background: In February 2026, While presenting the Union Budget for Financial Year 2026-27 (FY27), Union Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Ministry of Finance (MoF), announced the setting up of the committee.

Composition: Apart from the charmain, the committee comprises members that include: Shirish Chandra Murmu, Deputy Governor, Reserve Bank of India (RBI); Padmaja Chunduru, former Managing Director (MD) & Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Indian Bank; and N S Vishwanathan, former Deputy Governor, RBI.

- In addition, the Joint Secretary (Banking), Department of Financial Services (DFS), MoF, has been appointed as the Member Secretary of the committee.



Terms of Reference (ToR):

Review of Banking Regulations: The committee will examine the existing regulatory and legislative frameworks governing banks, including Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) and cooperative banks, and recommend reforms to strengthen the banking system.

Global Banking Practices: It will assess existing banking practices and prudential norms, identify international best practices and prepare a roadmap for developing globally competitive banks.

Capital Requirements: The committee will evaluate the long-term capital requirements of banks, Development Financial Institutions (DFIs) and Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs) to support India's growing economy.

Cost of Capital: It will examine differences in the cost of capital for businesses and recommend measures to encourage private investment and sustainable economic growth.

Emerging Technologies: The committee will prepare a roadmap for adopting **Artificial Intelligence (AI)** and digital innovation in banking institutions, along with safeguards against cybersecurity risks.

Talent Acquisition: It will recommend measures for talent acquisition, skill development and capacity building to create a future-ready banking workforce.

Financial Inclusion: The committee will review the **Priority Sector Lending (PSL)** framework and **Lead Bank Scheme (LBS)** to assess their relevance, effectiveness and coordination in promoting inclusive, balanced and data-driven credit delivery.

Additional Mandate: The committee may also examine other banking-related matters referred to it by the GoI.

About Ministry of Finance (MoF):

Union Minister- Nirmala Sitharaman (Rajya Sabha- Karnataka)
Minister of State **(MoS)-** Pankaj Chaudhary (Constituency- Maharajganj, Uttar Pradesh, UP)

PM Narendra Modi inaugurates ESTIC 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

In October 2026, Prime Minister **(PM) Narendra Modi** inaugurated the 2nd edition of Emerging Science, Technology and Innovation Conclave **(ESTIC 2026) ,** India's flagship annual Science, Technology and Innovation (STI) event, held from October 27 to 29, 2026 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, Delhi.

- PM Narendra Modi urged the scientific community and deep-tech startups to deliver measurable, scalable technological outcomes within a **3 year-window.**

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Inauguration of ESTIC 2026
- ✓ **Inaugurated by:** PM Narendra Modi
- ✓ **Venue:** Bharat Mandapam (New Delhi)
- ✓ **2026 Theme:** "Creative Minds, Catalyzing Science, Empowering Technologies"
- ✓ **Organiser:** CSIR & CSIR-NIIST
- ✓ **New Initiative:** Global Connect Networking Event.



About ESTIC 2026:

Theme: The event, held under the theme "Creative Minds, Catalyzing Science, Empowering Technologies", was organised by the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research **(CSIR)** Ministry of Science and Technology (MoS&T) in partnership with CSIR-National Institute for Interdisciplinary Science and Technology **(CSIR-NIIST).**

Thematic Areas: The event was centered around **12** key thematic areas, including generative and autonomous Artificial Intelligence (AI), biotechnology, quantum communication, agri-tech, advanced materials, manufacturing, healthcare, energy, climate science and ocean research, among others.

Global Connect Networking Event: A new initiative brought together over 300 invited participants to promote international research partnerships, industry-academia collaboration and commercialisation of innovations.

About CSIR: Founded in 1942, CSIR is India's premier Research & Development (R&D) organization with headquarters in New Delhi, Delhi.

Union MoS Sanjay Seth Inaugurates विश्व-2026 (VISV-2026) at Maneskshaw Centre in New Delhi

In October 2026, Union Minister of State **(MoS) Sanjay Seth,** Ministry of Defence (MoD), inaugurated '**विश्व-2026** (VISV-2026: Vision, Innovation, Synergy, Values)', held under the theme "Showcasing Defence Capabilities, Strengthening Global Partnerships", at Manekshaw Centre in New Delhi (Delhi).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **Event:** Inauguration of विश्व-2026
- ✓ **Inaugurated by:** Union MoS Sanjay Seth, MoD
- ✓ **Venue:** Manekshaw Centre (New Delhi, Delhi)
- ✓ **Organiser:** DRDO in collaboration with CENJOWS
- ✓ **Theme**: Showcasing Defence Capabilities, Strengthening Global Partnerships
- ✓ **Key Release:** Foreign-language compendium of DRDO products.

About VISV-2026:

Organised by: The event was organised by the Defence Research and Development Organisation **(DRDO)** in partnership with the Centre for Joint Warfare Studies **(CENJOWS).**

Four Pillars: The event aimed to promote indigenous defence technologies, self-reliance and global partnerships, guided by four pillars: Vision, Innovation, Synergy and Values, aligned with Viksit Bharat 2047.

Publication: Union MoS Sanjay Seth released a foreign-language compendium of DRDO products in **Arabic, Spanish and French,** aimed at promoting India's indigenous defence technologies among international partners.

About CENJOWS: It is an Indian tri-service defense think tank raised on August 27, 2007. It is registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860 and works under the MoD with headquarters in New Delhi, Delhi.

Department of Posts Releases Commemorative Postage Stamps on Breast Cancer Awareness

In October 2026, the Department of Posts (**DoP**), Ministry of Communications, released a special souvenir sheet featuring **two commemorative postage stamps,** with face values of Rs.25 and Rs.50, and **picture postcards** on **Breast cancer awareness** at Dak Bhawan, New Delhi, Delhi to mark International Breast Cancer Awareness Month.

- The stamps were jointly unveiled by **Manisha Sinha**, Director General (DG) of Postal Services, and **Punya Salila Srivastava**, Secretary, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW)

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of commemorative postage stamps on breast cancer awareness
- ✓ **Released By:** DoP, Ministry of Communications
- ✓ **Unveiled By:** Manisha Sinha, DG of Postal Services & Punya Salila Srivastava, Secretary, MoHFW
- ✓ **Souvenir Sheet:** Stamps: 2 stamps (Rs. 25 and Rs. 50) with picture postcards
- ✓ **Objective:** Promote breast cancer awareness, early detection and preventive healthcare
- ✓ **Occasion:** Breast Cancer Awareness Month (October).

About Commemorative Postage Stamps:

Design: The stamps feature breast cancer awareness imagery, highlighting the importance of early detection, screening and timely treatment. They were issued together in a special souvenir sheet.

Collaboration: The DoP, with technical support from the MoHFW, launched the initiative to promote early cancer detection, regular screening and preventive healthcare through its postal network, supporting the National Programme for Prevention and Control of Non-Communicable Diseases (NP-NCD).

Availability: The souvenir sheet can be purchased nationwide through Philately Bureaus and the official e-Post Office portal: https://www.epostoffice.gov.in/.

Breast Cancer Awareness Month: Observed annually from 1 to 31 October to promote early detection, education and support for people affected by breast cancer.

MoLE Constitutes National Social Security Board for Unorganised, Gig and Platform Workers

In October 2026, the Ministry of Labour and Employment **(MoLE)** notified the constitution of the **two** National Social Security Board **(NSSB)** for Unorganised Workers and Gig and Platform Workers under the **Code on Social Security, 2020,** to strengthen statutory social security planning and welfare monitoring.

- The boards have a **three-year tenure**, are chaired by Union Minister **Mansukh Mandaviya**, MoLE, with **Dr. Chandra Bhushan Kumar**, Secretary of MoLE, as Vice-Chairperson, and must meet at least three times a year, following Government of India (GoI) procedures.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** National Social Security Board constituted for unorganized, gig and platform workers.
- ✓ **By Whom?** MoLE

- ✓ **Notified On:** 30 October 2026.
- ✓ **Under Which Code:** Code on Social Security, 2020.
- ✓ **Chairperson:** Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, MoLE.
- ✓ **Meetings:** At least three times a year.
- ✓ **Main Role:** Recommend and monitor welfare schemes.

Highlights of the National Social Security Board:

Composition: The Unorganised Workers' Board includes representatives from trade unions, employers' organisations, civil society, Members of Parliament (MPs), Central Ministries and State Governments, with the Director General (DG) of Labour Welfare as its ex-officio Member-Secretary.

- The Gig and Platform Workers' Board includes five aggregators, Eternal Group, Swiggy, Zepto, Urban Company and Rapido, and worker representatives from the Indian Federation of App-Based Transport Workers (IFAT), Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh (BMS), National Front of Indian Trade Unions (NFITU) and Trade Union Coordination Centre (TUCC).

Functions: The boards recommend suitable social security schemes, advise the Central Government on Code-related matters, monitor centrally administered welfare schemes, review State-level record-keeping and expenditure from relevant funds and accounts, and perform other functions assigned by the Centre.
Framework: The Code on Social Security, 2020, was enacted in September 2020, came into effect on 21 November 2025 and replaced nine central labour laws; Section 6 establishes the National Social Security Board for unorganised workers, while Section 114(6) assigns its responsibilities concerning gig and platform workers through separate membership.
Categories: Gig workers earn through arrangements outside the traditional employer–employee relationship, whereas platform workers undertake work through or with online platforms, including food-delivery and ride-hailing applications.

IN-SPACe Selects Six Private Space Companies for AI INSPIRED Grants of Up to Rs 1 Crore Each

In October 2026, the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre **(IN-SPACe),** under the Department of Space (DoS), selected **six** private space-sector companies for seed-fund grants of up to **Rs 1 crore** each under its Artificial Intelligence **(AI) INSPIRED** (AI for INnovating Space Performance with Intelligent Resilient Engines Development) Opportunities in Space Sector programme.

- The programme aims to support AI-based solutions in areas such as precision landing, space surveillance, space debris detection and spacecraft autonomy.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Six private space-sector entities selected for seed-fund grants
- ✓ **By Whom?** IN-SPACe
- ✓ **Programme:** AI INSPIRED
- ✓ **Total Outlay:** Up to Rs 6 crore, up to Rs 1 crore per selected entity
- ✓ **Selected Start-ups:** Agnikul Cosmos, Digantara, EON Space Labs, OrbitAid Aerospace, Omnipresent Robot Technologies and TakeMeToSpace.

About Six Selected Start-ups:

Funding: With an outlay of up to **Rs. 6 crore,** the programme supports startups and Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs) in developing indigenous AI-based space technologies across three areas: Edge Intelligence in Orbit, Space for Earth Intelligence and Smart Access to Space.
Selected Start-ups: The six selected entities are Agnikul Cosmos (AI-based precision landing), Digantara (space object evaluation), EON Space Labs (space debris detection), OrbitAid Aerospace (satellite servicing and refuelling), Omnipresent Robot Technologies (automated target recognition for defence and docking) and TakeMeToSpace (AI-based spacecraft autonomy and control).

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About IN-SPACe: Established on 24 June 2020, it is a single-window autonomous agency under the Department of Space (DOS), headquartered in Ahmedabad, Gujarat, and chaired by Dr. Pawan Goenka.

INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS

World Bank Report: India Records One of the World's Fastest Poverty Declines in 12 Years, to 2.6%

In October 2026, the World Bank (WB) released its latest report titled "India Poverty and Equity Brief: October 2026", highlighting that India's extreme poverty rate declined from 27.1% in 2011 to **2.6% in 2023,** marking one of the fastest poverty reductions globally over 12 years.

- The report estimated that **496 million people** moved above the lower-middle-income poverty threshold of USD 4.20 per day, measured using 2021 Purchasing Power Parity (PPP).

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Release of report titled "Poverty and Equity Belief: October 2026"
- ✓ **Released by:** World Bank
- ✓ **Period Covered: 2**011–2023 (12 years)
- ✓ **Extreme Poverty Rate in India:** Declined from 27.1% to 2.6% (between 2011 and 2023)
- ✓ **Extreme Poverty Line:** USD 3 per day (2021 PPP)
- ✓ **People Lifted Above USD 4.20 Poverty Line:** 496 million
- ✓ **Key Drivers:** robust consumption growth, improvement in employment; and expanded social transfers (including food subsidies)
- ✓ **Non-monetary Poverty Rate:** 16.4% (2019-21).

Key Findings:

Key Drivers: The report cited that the poverty rate decline was mainly attributed to the robust consumption growth, improvement in employment, particularly women; and expanded social transfers, including food subsidies.

LMI Poverty Line: Also, the proportion of people living below the Lower-Middle-Income Country (LMIC) poverty line of USD 4.20 per day (measured at 2021 Purchasing Power Parity, PPP), declined **from 57.7% to 16.1%** during the period.

Key Projection: The report further projected that the poverty rate (at the USD 4.20 per day threshold) could decline in the next 2 years, although at a slower pace i.e. from 14.2% (in 2026) to **12.1% (by 2028).**

Non-monetary Poverty: As per the WB's latest report, non-monetary poverty, which is measured through the Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative **(OPHI)'s** Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI) has also decreased from 53.8% (in 2005-06) **to 16.4% (2019-21).**

- The report also showed that WB's multidimensional poverty measure stood at 15.5% (in 2022-23).

Gini Index: The WB reported India's Gini Index at **23.0** in 2023, measuring income or consumption inequality on a scale of 0 to 100, where 0 indicates perfect equality and 100 represents maximum inequality.

Geographical Poverty Disparities: In 2023, poverty at the USD 4.20-per-day threshold was higher in rural areas (19.3%) than in urban areas (8.6%), with around 57% of India's poor population concentrated in a belt stretching from Uttar Pradesh (UP) to West Bengal (WB).

Key Challenges: However, the report outlined some of the key factors that could impede the poverty rate decline such as: regional and employment-related challenges.

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- **Regional Barrier:** The report noted that though living standards improved across most Indian states, households in a contigious belt stretching from Uttar Pradesh (UP) to West Bengal (WB) account for nearly 57% of India's poor population.
- **Wage Disparities:** The report identified wage disparities will continue to be the dominant factor as median earnings among the top 10% of workers were about 13 times those of the bottom 10% in 2023.
- **Youth Unemployment:** The report further noted that employment increased by about 134 million people between 2017 and 2023. Despite this, youth unemployment rose from 14.6% in the 1st Quarter (Q1: April-June) of Financial Year 2025-26 (FY26) to 15.9% (in Q1FY27), particularly among rural young women.

About World Bank (WB):

President- Ajay Banga
Headquarters- Washington, DC, the United States of America (USA)
Established- 1944

BANKING & FINANCE

ADB Approves USD 139.55 Million Loan for Urban Development in Puducherry

In October 2026, the Asian Development Bank **(ADB)** approved a **USD 139.55 million loan** for the Puducherry Integrated Urban Livability Improvement Project **(PIULIP)**, marking ADB's first engagement in the Union Territory (UT) of Puducherry.

- The project aims to enhance urban livability through climate-resilient water supply, sewerage and sanitation infrastructure, modernised public spaces, and strengthened municipal governance and service delivery.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** USD 139.55 million loan approved for Puducherry.
- ✓ **By Whom?** Asian Development Bank (ADB).
- ✓ **Project:** Puducherry Integrated Urban Livability Improvement Project.
- ✓ **First Engagement:** ADB's first engagement in the UT of Puducherry.
- ✓ **Water Supply:** 100 km upgraded; 80 km new pipelines.
- ✓ **Sewerage:** 270 km underground network.
- ✓ **Treatment Capacity**: 50 MLD.
- ✓ **Beneficiaries:** Over 320,000 people.

Highlights of the Puducherry Urban Development Project:

Water Supply: Upgrade **100** Kilometres **(km)** of existing water supply networks, lay 80 km of new pipelines, construct overhead service reservoirs and establish district metered areas and brackish-water reverse osmosis **(RO)** desalination plants.

Sewerage: Build **270 km of underground** sewer networks, rehabilitate 80 km of existing networks and establish a sewage treatment plant with a capacity of 50 million litres per day **(MLD).**

Urban Infrastructure: Develop 4.5 km of pedestrian walkways accessible to persons with disabilities and improve drainage through concrete lining and stabilisation to reduce flooding, accidents and extreme-weather impacts.

Governance: Improve revenue collection, upgrade financial management systems and introduce a digital municipal service management platform to strengthen municipal capacity and financial sustainability.

Planning & Outcomes: Integrate water security and inclusive sanitation planning to enhance urban resilience and institutional capacity, benefiting over 320,000 people.

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About Asian Development Bank (ADB):

Overview: The Asian Development Bank (ADB) is a leading multilateral development bank established to promote sustainable, inclusive and resilient economic growth across Asia and the Pacific.
Role: It supports developing member countries through financial assistance, innovative funding mechanisms and strategic partnerships to improve infrastructure, strengthen economies and enhance the quality of life.
Shareholding: Japan, United States of America (USA), China, India and Australia are major shareholders; India holds 6.317% (as of 31 December 2020).
President – Masato Kanda
Headquarters – Mandaluyong, Metro Manila, Philippines.
Established – 1966
Members – 69 countries

Upstox Receives SEBI Approval to Operate as Online Bond Platform Provider

In October 2026, the broking firm **Upstox** (Upstox Securities Private Limited) received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (**SEBI**) to operate as an Online Bond Platform Provider (**OBPP**), enabling it to offer corporate bonds directly to investors.

- The approval places Upstox alongside major brokerage firms such as Groww, Zerodha and Angel One in the fixed-income investment segment.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Approval to operate as an Online Bond Platform Provider
- ✓ **Approved By:** SEBI
- ✓ **Approved Entity:** Upstox
- ✓ **Purpose:** Offer corporate bonds directly to investors
- ✓ **Minimum Planned Investment**: Rs. 1,000.

About OBPP approval:

Framework: SEBI introduced a stock exchange registration framework for OBPPs to regulate online debt-security platforms, with nearly **40 firms** receiving approval since 2023.
Access: The OBPP approval enables Upstox to offer bonds directly through its platform without third-party partnerships, replacing its earlier arrangement with IndiaBonds.
Bond Offerings: Corporate bonds are available on Upstox's platform with investments starting at **Rs. 1,000**, offers options across risk categories with indicative returns ranging from 8% to 16%.
Bond Ratings: The initial offering is expected to include bonds rated between AAA and BBB-, subject to availability, with an emphasis on relatively lower-risk securities.
About Upstox: Founded in 2009 as RKSV Securities Private Limited, Upstox was rebranded in 2016 and is headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra, with Ravi Kumar serving as its Chief Executive Officer (CEO).

AWARDS & RECOGNITIONS

PB Engineer Wins ABU Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026

In October 2026, **Nongmaithem Nandakumar Singh**, an engineer from **Prasar Bharati (PB)**, won the Asia-Pacific Broadcasting Union **(ABU)** Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026 for his contributions to broadcast technology and innovation.

- The award was received by **Mihir Kumar Jha**, Under Secretary, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB), on Singh's behalf.

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Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** ABU Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026
- ✓ **Winner:** Nongmaithem Nandakumar Singh
- ✓ **Organisation:** Prasar Bharati
- ✓ **Presented By**: Asia-Pacific Broadcasting Union (ABU).
- ✓ **Received By**: Mihir Kumar Jha, Under Secretary, MIB.
- ✓ **Key Innovations:** DDPlayout and DDSlowMo
- ✓ **ABU General Assembly**: 63rd edition.
- ✓ **Theme:** "Media for Peace and Humanity: Truth, Trust, and Transformation."

Highlights of the ABU Broadcast Engineering Excellence Award 2026:

Innovations:

- **DDPlayout:** Indigenous automated playout software adopted by multiple Doordarshan Kendras (DDKs).
- **DDSlowMo:** Cost-effective slow-motion replay system used in national-level sporting events.

ABU: The ABU, which presented the award, comprises around **224 broadcasting** and media organisations across 66 countries.

Assembly: The **63rd ABU** General Assembly and Associated Meetings were held in Colombo, Sri Lanka from 30 October to 3 November 2026 under the theme "Media for Peace and Humanity: Truth, Trust, and Transformation," featuring technical, programme and sports group meetings, the Broadcasting for All Forum, Media Leaders' Forum and Super Panel.

About PB: Established on 23 November 1997 under the Prasar Bharati (Broadcasting Corporation of India) Act, 1990, it comprises Akashvani (All India Radio) and Doordarshan (DD), is headquartered in New Delhi (Delhi), and is chaired by Prasoon Joshi.

APPOINTMENTS & RESIGNATIONS

IREDA Appoints Jatin Kumar Nayak as Chairman and Managing Director

On 30 October 2026, the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Limited **(IREDA)**, a Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE) under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), appointed **Jatin Kumar** Nayak as its Chairman and Managing Director **(CMD)**, with a tenure until 30 September 2029 or until further orders, whichever is earlier.

- His appointment was approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet **(ACC)** through an order issued by the MNRE.
- He succeeded **Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty,** who was holding the additional charge of CMD of IREDA.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of CMD of IREDA
- ✓ **Who?** Jatin Kumar Nayak
- ✓ **Predecessor:** Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty (Additional Charge)
- ✓ **Previous Position:** Executive Director (Finance), REC Limited.

About Jatin Kumar Nayak:

Experience: Has over three decades of experience in the power sector and resource-intensive industries, including mining and metals.

Areas of Expertise: Domestic and international resource mobilisation, strategic treasury management, corporate finance, taxation, legal affairs, project appraisal and monitoring, lending operations, loan recovery and stressed asset management.

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Previous Position: Served as Executive Director (Finance) at **REC Limited** (formerly Rural Electrification Corporation Limited), a Maharatna Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE) under the Ministry of Power (MoP).
Previous Organisations: Worked with NHPC Limited (formerly National Hydroelectric Power Corporation), Hindustan Copper Limited **(HCL)**, National Aluminium Company Limited **(NALCO)** and Neelachal Ispat Nigam Limited **(NINL)**.

About Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Limited (IREDA)

IREDA is a Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE) owned by the Government of India (GoI) and functioning under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE).
Headquarters -New Delhi, Delhi
Established – 1987

Air Marshal Inderpal Singh Walia Appointed as Next Vice Chief of the IAF

In October 2026, Air Marshal **Inderpal Singh Walia**, currently serving as Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief **(AOC-in-C)** of the Eastern Air Command, was appointed as the next Vice Chief of the Air Staff **(VCAS)** of the Indian Air Force (**IAF**), effective from 1 November 2026.

- He will succeed Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, who has been appointed as the 29th Chief of the Air Staff (CAS), in the rank of Air Chief Marshal, effective from 31 October 2026.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Appointment of Next Vice Chief of the Air Staff
- ✓ **Who**? Air Marshal Inderpal Singh Walia
- ✓ **Effective From** – 1 November 2026.
- ✓ **Succeeded** – Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit.
- ✓ **Awards:** Vayu Sena Medal (2008) and Ati Vishisht Seva Medal (2018)

Highlights of Air Marshal Inderpal Singh Walia's Appointment:

Profile: He was an alumnus of the National Defence Academy **(NDA)**, was commissioned into the Indian Air Force (IAF) fighter stream on 11 June 1988.
Aircraft: Commanded a frontline fighter squadron, Tactics and Air Combat Development Establishment **(TACDE)** and Air Force Station Bareilly; qualified to fly MiG-21, MiG-23, MiG-27, Jaguar and Su-30MKI fighter aircraft.
Assignments: Headed the Directorate of Air Staff Inspection (DASI), served as Defence Attaché in Japan and South Korea, and Senior Air Staff Officer of Eastern Air Command.
Awards: Received the Vayu Sena Medal **(VM)** in 2008 and Ati Vishisht Seva Medal **(AVSM)** in 2018.
About IAF: Established on 8 October 1932, is headquartered in New Delhi, Delhi, India, and operates under the Ministry of Defence (MoD).

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

ISRO Successfully Launches NVS-03 Satellite Aboard GSLV-F18 from Sriharikota, AP

On 30 October 2026, Indian Space Research Organisation (**ISRO**) successfully launched its next-generation navigation satellite (**NVS-03**) aboard the Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (**GSLV-F18**) from the Second Launch Pad (**SLP**), Satish Dhawan Space Centre (**SDSC**), Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh (AP)

- The mission marks the **20th** GSLV flight and restores India's indigenous Navigation with Indian Constellation (**NavIC**) system to its minimum operational configuration of **four** satellites.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Successful launch of NVS-03.

- ✓ **Launched by:** ISRO
- ✓ **Launch vehicle:** GSLV-F18.
- ✓ **Launch site:** Satish Dhawan Space Centre, Sriharikota, AP.
- ✓ **GSLV Project & Mission Director:** Thomas Kurian
- ✓ **Satellite weight:** Approximately 2,250 kg.
- ✓ **Satellite series:** 3rd satellite in ISRO's next-generation navigation satellite series.
- ✓ **Navigation system:** NavIC, formerly known as IRNSS
- ✓ **Orbit:** GTO
- ✓ **Achievement:** Restored NavIC to its minimum operational configuration of 4 satellites.

Background:

- On May 29, 2023, ISRO successfully launched the GSLV-F12/NVS-01 mission, injecting the first second-generation NavIC satellite into orbit.
- On January 29 2025, ISRO successfully launched GSLV-F15/NVS-02 mission, carrying the NVS-02 satellite, from the SLP SDSC in Sriharikota (marking ISRO's historic 100th spaceflight launch from the spaceport).

Expansion: V. Narayanan, Chairman, ISRO announced plans to establish four functional launch pads by **2029**, including a dedicated Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (**SSLV**) launch complex at Kulasekarapattinam, Tamil Nadu (TN), and a third launch pad at Sriharikota, AP.

About GSLV-F18

Overview: Developed by ISRO, GSLV-F18 is a three-stage launch vehicle using solid, liquid and cryogenic propulsion systems to place satellites into Geosynchronous Transfer Orbit (GTO).

Specifications: GSLV-F18 is approximately 50m (metres) tall, with a lift-off mass of around 420 tonnes, and uses four 40-tonne-class liquid-fuel (L40) strap-on boosters.

About NVS-03 Satellite:

Overview: NVS-03 is the **third** satellite in ISRO's second-generation navigation series, designed to ensure continuity, improve availability and enhance the capabilities of India's indigenous NavIC system.

Deployment: The **2,250-kg** (kilogram) NVS-03 satellite separated from the launch vehicle and reached its intended elliptical Geosynchronous Transfer Orbit (**GTO**) in approximately 18 minutes.

- **Thomas Kurian** served as the GSLV Project Director and Mission Director

Turnaround: The launch campaign was completed in **47 days**, with the four **L40** strap-on prepared in a record **37 days**, and a 56-day gap between successive GSLV missions, marking ISRO's shortest turnaround time for the launch vehicle.

Atomic Clock: NVS-03 carries an indigenously developed atomic clock alongside procured atomic clocks, adding the third indigenous atomic clock to India's NavIC constellation.

Navigation: NVS-03 introduces the L1 frequency band alongside the existing L5 and S-band signals, expanding NavIC's capabilities and applications and enhancing navigation services for civilian and strategic users.

Coverage: Designed to cover India's landmass and extend navigation services up to 1,500 km beyond India's geopolitical boundary.

About NavIC Systems:

Development: Developed by ISRO and formerly known as the Indian Regional Navigation Satellite System (**IRNSS**), NavIC is India's regional satellite navigation system providing independent Positioning, Navigation and Timing (PNT) services across India

Applications: NavIC supports transportation, disaster management, fisheries, military and strategic operations, telecommunications, and personal navigation through round-the-clock ground infrastructure.

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Configuration: The original NavIC constellation was designed with seven satellites, comprising three in geostationary orbits at 32.5°E (East longitude), 83°E and 129.5°E, and four in inclined geosynchronous orbits across two orbital planes with an inclination of 29°.
One Nation One Time Project: NavIC supports India's efforts to develop indigenous timing and synchronisation capabilities.

About Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO):
Chairman- V Narayanan
Headquarters– Bengaluru, Karnataka
Established– 1969

OBITUARY

Former Rajya Sabha MP Ravindra Kishore Sinha Passed Away at 75

In October 2026, veteran Bharatiya Janata Party **(BJP)** leader and former Rajya Sabha Member of Parliament (MP) **Ravindra Kishore Sinha** passed away at the age of 75 in Noida, Uttar Pradesh (UP).

- He was born on 22 September 1951 in Bahiyara village, Bhojpur district, Bihar.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** Former Rajya Sabha MP passed away
- ✓ **Who?** Ravindra Kishore Sinha.
- ✓ **Where?** Noida, UP
- ✓ **Political Party:** BJP
- ✓ **Rajya Sabha Election:** 2014(Bihar)
- ✓ **Company Founded**: Security and Intelligence Services.

About Ravindra Kishore Sinha:

Career: He began his career as a journalist with a Hindi newspaper and worked as a war correspondent during the 1971 India–Pakistan War.
Entrepreneurship: In 1974, he founded **Security and Intelligence Services (SIS),** providing employment opportunities to retired defence personnel. The company subsequently expanded into security and business support services.
Political Career: He was among the early members of the BJP and served on its National Executive Committee. He was elected to the Rajya Sabha from Bihar in 2014 and served until 9 April 2020.

IMPORTANT DAYS

National Unity Day 2026 – October 31

National Unity Day or Rashtriya Ekta Diwas is observed annually across India on **31 October** to commemorate the **birth anniversary** of **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel,** popularly known as the "Iron Man of India."

- 31 October 2026 marks the **151st** birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** National Unity Day or Rashtriya Ekta Diwas 2026
- ✓ **When?** October 31, 2026
- ✓ **Commemoration:** 151st birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel
- ✓ **First Observed:** 31 October 2014
- ✓ **2026 Events:** PM Modi led the event at Ekta Nagar, Narmada district, Gujarat
- ✓ **Development Projects:** Projects worth over Rs 400 crore inaugurated

- ✓ **Cultural Festival:** Bharat Parv 2026 inaugurated
- ✓ **Parade:** Rashtriya Ekta Diwas Parade 2026 held
- ✓ **2026 Awards:** Sardar Patel National Unity Award and Kendriya Grihmantri Dakshata Padak

Background:

Declaration: In **2014,** the Government of India (GoI), led by Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, declared 31 October, the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, as National Unity Day to honour his contribution to uniting India.

First Observation: The first National Unity Day (Rashtriya Ekta Diwas) was observed on **31 October 2014.**

About Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel:

Birth: Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel was born on 31 October 1875 in Nadiad, Gujarat, and pursued a career as a lawyer

Leadership: In 1931, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel was elected President of the Indian National Congress (INC), and on 15 August 1947, he became independent India's first Deputy PM and Home Minister under PM Jawaharlal Nehru, also serving as the country's first Minister of Information and Broadcasting.

Contribution: He played a key role in establishing the modern All India Services (AIS) system, earning the title "Patron Saint of India's Civil Servants."

Title: His commitment to national integration in newly independent India earned him the sobriquet "Iron Man of India."

Statue: The Statue of Unity, dedicated to him on 31 October 2018, stands approximately 182 metres (m) (597 feet, ft) tall and is recognised as the world's tallest statue; it was constructed by the GoI at a cost of approximately USD 420 million.

Demise: He died on 15 December 1950 at Birla House in Bombay (now Mumbai), Maharashtra.

2026 Events:

Coordination: The 2026 National Unity Day celebrations at the Statue of Unity, Ekta Nagar, Gujarat, are primarily coordinated by the Ministry of Home Affairs **(MHA),** in collaboration with the Government of Gujarat and the Statue of Unity Area Development and Tourism Governance Authority (SOUADTGA).

Occasion: On 31 October 2026, **PM Narendra Modi** led the celebrations of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel's 151st birth anniversary at **Ekta Nagar, Gujarat,** and paid floral tributes at the Statue of Unity, while Indian Air Force (IAF) helicopters showered flower petals over the world's tallest statue.

Development Projects: PM Modi inaugurated, dedicated to the nation and laid the foundation stone for development projects worth over **Rs. 400 crore** at Ekta Nagar, Gujarat, including a sewage and water treatment plant, façade lighting, upgradation of Narmada Ghat, a Rainforest project, an Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) hotel and the Ekta Cruise.

Bharat Parv 2026: PM Modi inaugurated Bharat Parv 2026 at Ekta Nagar, Gujarat, as part of the Rashtriya Ekta Diwas celebrations. The festival, themed "Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat," will continue until 15 November 2026, showcasing India's cultural diversity, traditions, cuisines, crafts and heritage.

Ekta Prakash Parv: The festival features a 530-metre(m) illuminated stretch and a 180-metre Glow Tunnel powered by over 1.5 crore Light Emitting Diode (LED) lights, along with the Narmada Maha Aarti at the upgraded Shoolpaneshwar Narmada Ghat.

Parade: Approximately 10,000 police and paramilitary personnel participated in the **Rashtriya Ekta Diwas Parade 2026**, featuring 16 marching contingents from nine States, one Union Territory (UT), the National Cadet Corps (NCC) and four Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs).

- The parade featured the National Security Guard (NSG) Hell March, motorcycle daredevil performances by Border Security Force (BSF) and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) bikers, K9 units and an Indian Air Force (IAF) flypast by the Surya Kiran aerobatic team.

National Awards 2026:

Sardar Patel National Unity Award: The award is highly restricted, with a maximum of **three recipients**

per year, and carries a medal and certificate without monetary prize; it is equivalent in status to the Padma Vibhushan, with over 150 entries undergoing background verification for the 2026 announcement on 31 October.

- Instituted in 2019 by the GoI through the MHA, the award recognises outstanding contributions by individuals, institutions and organisations towards promoting national unity and integrity.

Kendriya Grihmantri Dakshata Padak: Instituted by MHA on 1 February 2024, the medal recognises excellence in operations, investigation, intelligence, exceptional performance and forensic science; 490 personnel from States, Union Territories (UTs), Central Police Organisations (CPOs) and Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) received it for 2026, with the award announced annually on 31 October.

About Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA):

Union Minister – Amit Shah (Constituency – Gandhinagar, Gujarat)

Minister of State **(MoS)** – Nityanand Rai (Constituency – Ujiarpur, Bihar); Bandi Sanjay Kumar (Constituency – Karimnagar, Telangana)

World Vegan Day 2026 – November 1

World Vegan Day **(WVD)** is observed globally on **November 1** every year to promote veganism, animal welfare and the benefits of a vegan lifestyle.

Exam Hints:

- ✓ **What?** World Vegan Day 2026
- ✓ **When?** November 1, 2026
- ✓ **Purpose:** To promote veganism and animal welfare
- ✓ **First Observed:** 1 November 1994
- ✓ **Founder:** Louise Wallis
- ✓ **Organisation:** The Vegan Society, UK
- ✓ **World Vegan Month:** 1–30 November.

Background:

Origin: WVD was established in **1994** by **Louise Wallis**, then Chair of The Vegan Society, to commemorate the organisation's 50th anniversary.

The Vegan Society: The organisation was founded in November 1944 in the United Kingdom **(UK)** by **Donald Watson** and five other founding members to promote a lifestyle free from animal exploitation.

First Observance: The first WVD was observed on **1 November 1994.**

World Vegan Month: Celebrated worldwide throughout **November,** beginning with World Vegan Day on 1 November. It evolved from World Vegan Day to World Vegan Week and later World Vegan Month.

Significance:

Origin of the Term 'Vegan': Coined by Donald Watson in November 1944, the word was formed from the first three and last two letters of **'vegetarian'**, meaning "the beginning and end of vegetarianism."

2026 Significance: Marks the 82nd anniversary of The Vegan Society and the 32nd anniversary of WVD.

About Veganism:

Overview: Veganism is a lifestyle that seeks to avoid animal exploitation and cruelty in food, clothing and other areas of life, as far as possible and practicable.

Types: It includes dietary veganism (avoiding animal-derived foods), ethical veganism (avoiding animal exploitation in all aspects of life) and environmental veganism (adopted to reduce environmental impact).

Food: Vegans avoid meat, fish, eggs, dairy products, honey and other animal-derived ingredients, choosing plant-based alternatives instead.

Benefits: Veganism promotes animal welfare and environmental sustainability. A well-planned vegan diet can provide essential nutrients and support good health.

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